

ANI

TARGET PRACTICE Rahul Gandhi with Priyanka Gandhi -Vadra during the Yatra in Khandwa, Madhya Pradesh

The three inhouse teams—led by Jairam, Shrinate and Srivatsa—are supported by a large number of volunteers and party workers who are generating content themselves. "I have never seen such euphoria among workers in my entire political career," says Kamal Nath, former Madhya Pradesh CM, and nine-time Lok Sabha MP. "The BJY has infused a different kind of energy into the organisation." One such worker's mobile phone provided one of the most viral images during the yatra—on October 6, in Karnataka, Rahul Gandhi bent down to tie his mother Sonia Gandhi's shoelaces, as she was walking with him. "There was no still camera around and it happened suddenly. We got the image from a grassroots worker," says Shrinate, who feels such sunshine moments cannot be planned. "Rahul Gandhi doesn't do things for the camera. But he does things like embracing an old lady or listening to a farmer out of genuine affection and sincerity. The challenge for those on the ground is to capture the moment. Nobody knows when that will happen. But because it happens spontaneously, we get the most inspiring and emotive images."

But to get such content, Shrinate's team has to sift through a large volume of images and videos every day and edit and package them to meet the requirements of different social media platforms. While they do that for the Congress's social media handles, including the one for BJY, the team led by Srivatsa curates content for Rahul's personal social media handle. There is regular coordination among the three teams about what has the potential to go viral and what is suitable for which social media platform. Not everything on the yatra is posted on INC social media handles, while the BJY handle focuses on yatra-related content.

It's no easy task for the three teams that total not even 80 members. Constantly supplied with an enormous volume of videos and visuals, they have to suitably repackage them, often in less than 30 minutes. At times, the supply chain is blocked, for the yatra passes through places with poor connectivity. Jammers—part of Rahul's security requirements—add barriers too. "Amid these challenges, the teams are constantly looking out for the right content. My barometer to pick the right content is how the team is reacting to the visuals. For instance, when Rohith Vemula's mother walked with Rahul Gandhi or Gauri Lankesh's mother and sister joined him, there were moist eyes in the room. Those were such poignant moments. These moments are making BJY so special and humane. It has gone beyond political messaging and touched people's hearts," says Shrinate.

RAHUL'S CANDID MOMENTS APART, MUCH OF BJY'S SOCIAL MEDIA PROMOTION IS PLANNED IN ADVANCE TO SET THE TONE AND NARRATIVE

But Rahul's spontaneity is not the only driving force behind BJY's social media promotion. Much of it is also planned and packaged in advance to set the tone and narrative. For instance, when Rahul was in Vidarbha, he talked about farmers' suicides in a press conference. Even before the event, the social media team in GRB was ready with backgrounders and graphics on farmers' suicides so that the posts gave viewers a context—why farmers' suicides is an important issue in Vidarbha. When Rahul interacted with MNREGA workers in Thiruvananthapuram, the team was ready with numbers related to the scheme to add context to his demand for making it relevant for the next generation.

Then there are late discoveries. For instance, in Karnataka, Rahul noticed an old woman standing with two cucumbers in her hand and, out of curiosity, struck up a conversation with her. The photograph of him with his hands around her shoulders came to the social media team. It was assumed to be just another old lady showering affection on the Gandhi scion. Later, they came to know that the conversation had a historical significance—the lady had grown the two cucumbers on land allocated to her under the 'Grower's Land Policy' when Indira Gandhi was the prime minister. She wanted to gift the cucumbers to Indira's grandson. No time was lost to repackage the visual with the emotional context.

Indeed, context has been critical for the Congress's social media warriors. For them, the BJY is history in the making and they are its ardent memory-keepers. "We did not anticipate its scale, but now it's unfolding as a watershed moment in the nation's political history," says Shrinate. The party's social media teams are trying their best to convince the nation to see the BJY through their historical prism. ■